Neil Hilborn Collection 2

By Neil Hilborn

INTRODUCTION

Neil Hilborn – One of the greatest Slam poets of all time. But what makes Hilborn special is his ability to talk about his experiences and how the pain of dealing with mental illness – OCD and Bi-Polar Disorder -- have dramatically impacted his life. As someone without a mental illness, I can only try to understand what living with a mental illness is like. Hopefully these poems will help you to understand too.

Not Dead (Pg 14)

When I say I'm on my way
I probably mean it, I probably
want to die less than I say I do,

but who knows, the statistics
are sporadic at best. I'll say I love
you when I actually love you.

We are in your mother's house
and I guess I want to be here. There's no
reason not to, I guess. I guess

4NG Fanatics

I'd rather be tattooing a bunch of triangles
on myself or ordering a steak
at an Indian restaurant or setting

all my s*** on fire, but none of those
are currently reasonable options. If anyone
is gonna kill me, it should be me.
The nearest place you can buy a gun
is only twenty minutes away. I'm not going

to tell you how to live your life, but maybe you should
listen to your feet when they tell you to run
away. Maybe you should get out of here,

then get out some more. I feel
like I've spent my whole life waiting
for this moment and now this moment

is terrible. This moment doesn't even
have any fireworks. This moment falls asleep
with its keys in its hand. It's not your fault,

probably because you didn't make me
this way, stupid, no, I mean I'm stupid.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

OCD (Pg 38)

The first time I saw her, everything
in my head went quiet. All the tics,
all the constantly refreshing images,
just disappeared. When you have

Obsessive Compulsive Disorder,
you don't really get quiet moments.
Even in bed I'm thinking

did I lock the door yes
did I wash my hands yes
did I lock the door yes.
did I wash my hands yes.

But when I saw her, the only thing
I could think about was the hairpin curve
of her lips or the eyelash on her chee

the eyelash on her cheek
the eyelash on her cheek

I knew I had to talk to her.
I asked her out six times.
In thirty seconds. She said yes

4NG Fanatics

after the third one, but none of them
felt right, so I had to keep going.

On our first date, I spent more time
organizing my meal by color
than I did eating or talking to her

but she loved it. She loved
that I had to kiss her goodbye
sixteen times or twenty-four times
if it was Wednesday. She loved that
it took me forever to walk home
because there are lots of cracks
in our sidewalk.

When we moved in together,
she said she felt safe, like no one would ever rob us
because I definitely lock the door
18 times. I'd always watch her mouth

when she talked when she talked when
she talked when she talked. When she said
she loved me, her mouth would curl up
at the edges. At night, she'd lay in bed
and watch me turn all the lights off and on

and off and on and off and on and off

NOT FOR EDUCATIONAL USE

and on and off. She'd close her eyes
and imagine that the days and nights
were passing in front of her.

Some mornings, I'd start kissing her
goodbye but she's just leave because
I was making her late for work.

When I stopped in front of a crack in the sidewalk,
she just kept walking. When she said
she loved me, her mouth was a straight line.
She told me I was taking up too much
of her time. Last week she started
sleeping at her mother's place.

She told me that she shouldn't
have let me get so attached to her;
that this whole thing was a mistake,
but how can it be a mistake

that I don't have to wash my hands
after I touch her? Love is not a mistake.
It's killing me that she can run away
from this and I just can't. I can't

go out and find someone new
because I always think of her.

4NG Fanatics

Usually, when I obsess over things,
I see germs sneaking into my skin.
I see myself crushed by an endless
succession of cars. She was the first

beautiful thing I ever got stuck on.
I want to wake up every morning
thinking about the way she

holds her steering wheel. How she turns
shower knobs like she opening a safe.
How she blows out candles blows out

candles blows out candles--
blows out candles blows out
candles blows out candles
blows out --

now I just think about who else
is kissing her. I can't breathe because
he only kisses her once. He doesn't care
if it's perfect. I want her back so bad,

I leave the door unlocked.
I leave the lights on.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

TRANSITION

Hilborn himself has explained in interviews that even though people have viewed the previous poem as a "love conquers all" poem. In reality he felt he saw her as a talisman to fix his mental illness. The relationship ended and he's back to feeling exactly how he did before. In his own words: "Somebody else isn't going to fix your mental health. The only, the only person that is going to fix whatever is going on in your head, is you." This next poem, Here and Away is Hilborn's attempt to understand himself.

Here and Away (Pg 53)

I've been hearing that the world is ending.
I've heard it so much these days
that I can either completely ignore it
or never leave my house again.
That is, if I actually left my house
for things that don't directly enable
me to keep my house. See, I've been thinking
about driving nowhere. I've been thinking
about becoming a box inside a locked room
inside a dark house at the dark end of the street.
I wanna go away until I'm gone. It takes so much
less energy to not exist than it does to exist

4NG Fanatics

and get burned. I've been burned so much
I'm not me anymore. I'm a stupid puppet version
of me. I've got strings that lead to nowhere.
Nothing is pulling on me. I wish someone
would drag my hand out of hiding
and sign my name on the dotted line.
There are days when I cannot find the sun
even though it's right outside my goddamn
window, when getting out of bed feels like the key
in the doomsday machine, so on those days,
this is what I tell myself: whatever
you are feeling right now, there is
a mathematical certainty that someone
is feeling the exact thing. This is not
to say you aren't special. This is to say
thank god you aren't special. I too
have kissed no one good night.
I have launched myself off tall places
and hoped no one would catch me.
I have ended relationships because suddenly
I was exposed. But isolation is not safety,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

it is death. If no one knows you're alive
you aren't. If a tree falls in the forest
and no one's around to hear it, it does
make a sound, but then that sound is gone.
I'm not saying you will find the meaning of life
in other people. Am saying that other people
are the life to which you provide the meaning.
See, we are wrong when we say I think,
therefore I am. The more we say it,
the more it sounds like, "I think,
therefore I wall be." You cannot think yourself
into a full table. You cannot think and make
walls and a roof appear around you.
I have thought and thought myself into corners
made words, nightmares, and what
has it gotten me but more thoughts,
a currency that only buys more currency.
So please, if you want to continue existing,
do something. . Learn to make clouds with only
your breath. Build a house, even if every wall
leans to the left. Love it anyway, just like a season.

4N6 Fanatics

just like a child. Love how you hate yourself sometimes,
because goddamn, at least there's still something
to hate. It's so easy to think and keep thinking
until you are the last person left on earth.
until the entire world is no larger than the space
between your bed and the light switch,
but I hear the world is ending soon.
when we go, and we're all going to go,
I will be part of it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Neil Hilborn
Book: Our Numbered Days
ISBN: 978-0989641562
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): April 2015

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY